sense, neither learning nor governmental office appears to insulate either man from ignorance.

No greater proof of this can be found than the Prime Minister himself. Narendra Modi likes to be portrayed as a technology-friendly 21st century leader, but on 25 October 2014, Modi startled the world at the inauguration of a Mumbai hospital with the claim that the elephant-headed Hindu god Ganesh was proof of ancient India's knowledge of plastic surgery. He went on to cite the ancient epic, the Mahabharata, as confirming that "people then were aware of genetic science."

That the smallest imaginable elephant head cannot possibly fit into the largest available human neck does not appear to have occurred to the Prime Minister, whose fatuous claim discredited ancient India's genuine scientific accomplishments. Such ideas, because they are patently absurd, except in the realm of metaphor, have embarrassed those who advance them as well as those who cite them in support of broader, but equally unsubstantiated, claims to past scientific advances from genetic science to cloning and interstellar travel and the use of nuclear devices (by the philosopher-sage Kanada in the first century BCE). Petty chauvinism is always ugly but never more so than in the field of science, where knowledge must be uncontaminated by ideology, superstition or irrational pride.

India was indeed the world pioneer in plastic surgery; it produced the world's first known surgeon, Susruta, and archaeologists have found the world's oldest surgical instruments (dating from the 1st century) in India. There is evidence for rhinoplasty operations in the ancient texts. But the moment these historical facts were subsumed in a narrative about mythological transplated elephant heads, the actual facts were discredited.

This was not the Prime Minister's only offence. Before heading off for the Paris climate change negotiations, Modi told schoolchildren on Teachers' Day in 2014 that climate change was a myth because it was actually human beings whose capacity to cope with heat and cold has changed, rather than the environment. Global warming, he explained on national television, "is just a state of mind." What made it worse was that this came as an answer to a schoolchild's question about climate change.